its abundance in farmlands, timber, gas, and hydropower could contribute to Bangladesh's needs. Finally, cooperation between Myanmar and Bangladesh should extend towards increasing contact between people through cultural exchanges, sport, education, and other mutually beneficial activities.

CONCLUSION

This chapter has drawn together strands of the debate on issues of border management and threat perceptions by Myanmar and Bangladesh. Imperceptible elements of fear, like the ethno-religious identities of the bordering people, rather than the tangible perception of threats have been the main reasons for confrontations between these two countries for many years. On a brighter side, the people of these countries enjoy ties rooted in their shared histories and cultures. Recovering from a number of diplomatic lows in the 1980s and 1990s, they are now showing signs of improvement in their relations: not only in diplomacy, but also in trade and investment, which could be used by the opposing border forces to increase mutual support and concerted engagement.

Nearly seventy years since independence, the state of Myanmar continues to be a state in formation. It remains one of the most conflict-prone in Asia, but it has much to be optimistic about. Today's Myanmar is identified as a country of many nations, races, ethnicities, and religions; a country that does not belong to any particular group — the majority Bamar or the minority Shan, Kachin, Kayah, Kayin, Rakhine, Rohingya, Mon, Karen, Chinese, or Indian. A democratic framework that genuinely protects the human rights and equality of every citizen of Myanmar without any discrimination is what the people of Myanmar could now aim and strive for. Such inclusiveness would be necessary not only to help re-socialize Myanmar's marginalized people — who, otherwise, may turn to violence and disruption — but would go a long way to see Myanmar's rise as a 'union' in the truest sense, and in so doing help to avert prolonged conflicts with its neighbours.